

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

GARLAND WARS

In the 2018 state election in Karnataka, giant-sized garlands strung together with apples and hoisted by a crane were the in thing at political rallies. This time, party workers are outdoing each other to come up with new objects to felicitate their leaders. The Janata Dal (Secular) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy has even found an entry in a book of records for the wide variety of garlands he has received since his Pancharathna Yatra began in November 2022. In January, Congress leader Siddaramaiah was offered a 1,000-kg garland made of the famous Mysore Pak sweet. That is not all. There have been garlands with coconuts, capsicum, sugarcane, onions, volleyballs, juice packets and milk cartons too!

FIGHT CLUB





All isn't well between the BJP and its Haryana ally, the **Dushyant Chautala**-led Jannayak Janata Party (JJP), in Hisar. **Brijendra Singh**, the incumbent MP from the saffron side, has become hyperactive, even as his father, former Union minister Birender Singh, and mother, former MLA Prem Lata, have launched scathing attacks on Chautala and the JJP. Chautala had defeated Prem Lata from Uchana Kalam, which falls within the Hisar Lok Sabha constituency, in the assembly polls. Birender Singh, meanwhile, is also unhappy with another turncoat family—that of Kuldeep Bishnoi, who had joined the BJP last year. The central leadership, meanwhile, is mum on these family feuds.

Favoured Suffix

Each of West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee's** government schemes carries the suffix 'Sree', which signifies prosperity or beauty. Road projects, for instance, are named Rastasree, schemes for youths become Yuvasree. Girls go for higher studies as part of Kanyasree and women can get married under Rupasree. The latest to be 'sree-fied' is Yogasree, the medical college and yoga and naturopathy hospital at Belur in Howrah. Originally a central government initiative, like all other Centre-state shared or aided projects, it was given a touch of 'sree' by Mamata for people in her state to feel a sense of ownership.



Hairy Affair



Wagering your moustache for electoral reasons is a long-standing Indian tradition. In Chhattisgarh, Ghar Wapsi champion Dilip Singh Judeo had offered to sacrifice his if the BJP did not come to power. The *mooch* survived. Twenty years on, tribal Congress leader and food minister **Amarjeet Bhagat** has said he'll sacrifice his whiskers if the Congress loses this year. Two BJP tribal leaders from the state have made a pledge for opposite outcomes. Nand Kumar Sai has said he'll lop off his long locks if the BJP loses; Ramvichar Netam has said he won't get a haircut till the BJP is voted back to power.



MUSLIM CARD

Aligarh Muslim University vice-chancellor **Prof. Tariq Mansoor** is the only Muslim among the six leaders who have been nominated to the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council. It will make Mansoor the first AMU V-C to join the BJP. Mansoor, who has good relations with RSS leaders, is set to retire on May 17 after his term was extended last year. Through him, the BJP is seeking to reach out to the Muslim intellectual community. With the Lok Sabha polls a year away, the BJP is betting big on Mansoor, who may be given an important responsibility in the Yogi government.

Kaushik Deka with Ajay Sukumaran, Anilesh Mahajan, Ashish Misra, Rahul Noronha and Romita Datta